

The City of Avitus

A Short Guide to the Main Neighbourhoods

The Old City (aka Elderton, or Saints' Island)

Located on Saints' Island at the confluence of the rivers Wen and Nith at Calder's Basin, this was the original site of the Elder City of Avitus. The oldest part of the city, the island is home to Imperial Square where the Cathedral of St Avitus, the Monastery of St Avitus, The Blue Palace of the Scion and The Palace of Saint Severinius line its sides. This has always been the traditional power centre of the city. For most of its history, the city was confined to the islands themselves, with nothing but farmland and brush on the mainland.

Sebald's Isle & Elder Isle

Adjacent to Saints' Island, Sebald's and Elder have long been the residential neighbourhoods of the city. As the city grew out in size unto the mainland, these two islands traditionally had been the location of the palaces and villas of various prelates, nobles and wealthy merchants. However, with the continued expansion and growth of the city out of the islands and onto the mainland, many of these have moved their residences to larger estates in the newer suburbs to the north, particularly to Newton Hill where the floodwaters of the River Wen do not reach. Today, Sebald's and Elder remain as largely residential neighbourhoods, although many of the palaces have since been gutted and subdivided into smaller houses and tenements now populated by members of the growing middle class.

Civic (aka The Fleet)

This district, located directly across from the islands on the eastern shore, used to be called "The Fleet", after its most storied resident, the Imperial Navy. Home to the original docks and shipyards of the Navy, this was a raucous, violent and impoverished neighbourhood for most of the city's history. With the coming of the Revolution, the new government chose The Fleet as the site of its new administrative and government centre, deciding to move it away from the church's influence in the Old City. It was hoped, as well, that by demolishing many of the slums and dark alleys of The Fleet, the neighbourhood might be invested with some semblance of respectability. In an attempt to buff up the image of the district, the city's new rulers renamed it "Civic Centre" and eventually "Civic" for short. However, there is not a man alive or dead in the city that calls this district by either of those names. This district has always been known as The Fleet, and continues to be referred to only by that name regardless of how the new maps have been labelled. It is of interest to note that, to date, virtually none of the improvements originally planned for this district have come to pass. Construction of the Parliament House and other government buildings has been slow and irregular throughout the centuries. Aside from the relative safety of the main thoroughfares, The Fleet remains one of the most vile, debauched, dangerous and dirty districts in the whole city.

Lord's

Originally the site of a large estate, this district to the north-west of The Fleet, and north of the islands on the shore is now largely composed exclusively of the University and its associated buildings and institutions. Although sitting on the banks of the River Wen, Lord's has the advantage of being located atop a small

series of hills, and thus, is typically spared much damage whenever the Wen floods.

Sever's Cross

This district, located east of Lord's and north of The Fleet, is the main commercial and trades district of the city. Sever's Cross is both residential and commercial, densely housing many of the city's more prosperous tradesmen and shops in large five and six storey buildings. A reasonably clean, safe and neatly maintained district, the old town of Sever's Cross is where most of the city's middle and upper classes come to shop, dine and seek entertainment in its theatres, clubs, bordellos and taverns. Sever's Cross also houses most of the city's markets, except for livestock (located, appropriately, in the district of Hog's Market) and fish (located at the Harbour).

Newton Hill

Located on a hill overlooking the city to the north of Sever's Cross and Lord's, Newton (or "New Town") is a sleepy, residential neighbourhood of large villas and palaces surrounded by clean parks and gardens. This is the wealthiest district in the city, and houses most of the city's upper class, prelates and nobles. The buildings here tend to be crowded around squares, and are palatial in appearance and size.

Northlund Road

Not a district as such, but more of a collection of villages and buildings lining the road north of the city along the east bank of the River Wen as it leaves Lord's and Newton. Northlund Road is what one might expect, housing a variety of tradesmen, shops, houses, inns, stockyards and houses of varying qualities and becoming more and more rural as it goes along.

The Green

The Green is a large, cultivated forest and park that marks the northern boundary of the city, and melds out into the wilderness. Near the city, The Green is mostly parklands and gardens, with the occasional farm. As it rolls out further north, the Green becomes wilder, and transforms into a forest. This forest is reserved exclusively as a hunting ground for the city's elite, though, in its wilder areas it is said to house escaped convicts and bands of other criminals.

Methwold

Located south of The Green, and east of Newton, this is another fairly well-to-do neighbourhood housing estates and villas of the nobility. Unlike Newton, the homes in Methwold tend to be much more spread out, reminiscent of country estates, rather than palaces.

The Harbour

South of Methwold and east of Sever's Cross across Severn Harbour, lies the district known only, and appropriately, as The Harbour. This is precisely what its name implies, holding the majority of the city's current docks, shipyards and warehouses. It is a largely industrial neighbourhood with little to offer outside of the nautical professions and associated trades (and even then the brothels and taverns of Sever's Cross are preferred by the sailors themselves.) Aside from this, The Harbour is also home to the city's main fish market.

Waverleigh, Chapelton & Pondluck

Located east of the harbour, the neighbourhoods of Waverleigh, Chapelton and Pondluck are, perhaps, indistinguishable from one another. They are poor, dirty, industrial districts which house most of the city's working poor. These neighbourhoods are home to the multitude masses of the city, and are punctuated by the black smoke of the factory fires. While it is not unusual for the more affluent citizens of the city to look down with scorn at these poor neighbourhoods, those with any bit of sense recognise that this is the necessary industrial engine that drives the city.

Saint Gideon

This neighbourhood is considered to be the latest casualty of the city's expansion. Prior to the Revolution, Saint Gideon was a prosperous town in its own right. These days, however, it has been swallowed up by the greater city of Avitus, and now forms one of its northern suburbs. Unlike many of the other neighbourhoods of the city, Saint Gideon retains much of its independent charm and character. It has its own town square, and its own hall, and retains its own town council. Many of Saint Gideon's wealthy elite have moved on to the nearby suburbs of Methwold and Newton, but many remain. Saint Gideon, in many ways, is as industrial an area as neighbouring Waverleigh, but it is decidedly cleaner and more prosperous in character.

The Marshes

The Marshes was built, appropriately, over drained marshland on the banks of the River Nith just to the east of Chapelton and Pondluck. The Marshes is a district that remains as poor as Chapelton and Pondluck, but, unlike those two, is rife with mass unemployment. The soft ground of The Marshes prevents the construction of buildings of any great size, so the factories and workhouses have not come here. This is perhaps the most impoverished district in the city.

Saint Pitt's Town

Like Saint Gideon, Saint Pitt's Town was an independent town that was annexed into the larger city over time. Unlike Saint Gideon, Saint Pitt's did not maintain its independent feel. Today, Saint Pitt's is a collection of stockyards, abandoned buildings, impoverished monasteries, and military barracks. Saint Pitt's only asset is that this is where some of the crusading orders gather, within easy distance of the necessary supply shops, but far enough away from the sinful temptations that may befall the young recruits. Saint Pitt's however, is a transient town. A waystation between the provinces and Lysander for these crusaders.

Landside & The Spit

Located south of the Harbour on the appropriate spit of land, these neighbourhoods are old, crumbling, and hold a mixture of impoverished citizens and prosperous tradesmen. Landside is a cousin to The Harbour, holding many warehouses, along with the tenements and inns that hold the sailors and fishermen that work out of the Harbour. The Spit, however, is undergoing a bit of a renaissance. Linked to The Fleet and the islands by boatmen, barges and ferries, The Spit has become a fashionable district for the young and ambitious merchants of the city. Buying up

property at a very cheap price in this district, many of these young men have turned this narrow strip of line into the financial centre of the city. Indeed, it is here that the Bank of Avitus is now located, and where the Exchange's building is under construction. With these young men and their businesses came the requisite service trades. New tea houses, taverns, restaurants and clubs have been opened up in remodelled buildings that had been left abandoned or condemned. Nowhere else in the city is there so much construction and optimism as in The Spit.

Highborough & Farmwalk

Located on the south bank of the River Nith, across the ferry from Landside and The Spit, Highborough is a city that grew up independently in its own right. It continues this independence today, being formally apart from Avitus. With its smaller suburb of Farmwalk, Highborough is actually little more than a middling market town serving the majority of the farmers on the south bank of the river. It is also the start of the Lysander Road, and as such, houses a great many inns.

Kingston (aka King's, The Bride, Hog Market & Black's Road)

Kingston was a city on the west bank of the River Wen, across from Avitus. No longer called "Kingston", since the Revolution, the western districts have been formally annexed into the city. The four western districts are a tumultuous, virtually lawless place of stockyards, slaughterhouses, animal pens, factories, coachhouses and seedy inns and brothels. Only the district of Hog's Market (site of both the city's live animal market, and the city's meat markets) holds any real degree of safety and security. This safety is brutally enforced by the district's Butchers Guild, who fear that crime and lawlessness may drive the city's rulers to establish a new livestock market elsewhere. The central district, referred to as King's, is no more than an impoverished commercial centre full of slums and decaying buildings. The Bride, which is the northern suburb, is a mostly residential area not unlike the Northlund Road district on the opposite bank of the river. Black's Road, which marks the westernmost part of the city, is the main point of entry for all who come from the western country. Named after a famous highwayman who terrorised the western road, the district of Black's Road is composed mostly of taverns, public houses, inns, coach-houses, caravan yards and animal pens servicing all who come in and out of the city.

A Note on the Waterways

The city is characterised by its four main bodies of water: The large and navigable River Nith leading out to the sea; the fast and rough River Wen flowing down from the northern mountains; the safe calm of Severn Harbour; and the cold, deep whirlpools of the Calder Basin. Much of the city's life revolves around the waterways. Countless boatmen and ferries ply their trade from any available spot on the banks in the absence of adequate bridges. A great multitude of floating shops can be found in Severn Harbour and along the banks of the Nith or between the isles, plying their trades from their boats and skiffs. While not a nautical culture, the rivers and waterways do play a fairly important part in the life of the city.

A Note on Floods

The River Wen often floods. However, it must be noted that the floods are almost invariably manmade in nature. Occasionally, heavy rains or a particularly wet winter in the north will cause the Wen to swell and break its banks, but, most often,

when the Wen floods it is due to garbage and debris creating a dam out of the bridge linking Lord's to King's.

When the river floods as a result of this carelessness, most of the water flows to the lower west bank, submerging King's and The Bride and, to a lesser extent, the other Kingston suburbs. A gully separates the hills of Lord's and Newton Hill creating a virtual canal along Lord's Road that funnels a great deal of the flood water down into The Fleet and out into the harbour and basin.

The manmade floods of the Wen are a perpetual annoyance, though, few efforts at fixing the situation have ever found success. The latest effort (undertaken last in the last century) saw the government construct a large underground canal directly beneath Lord's road from the bridge on the Wen to the Customs House in the harbour, which, it was hoped, would channel the excess water away. It was a solution that worked, until the canal became just as clogged with refuse and debris as the bridge itself, that is.

At present, The Fleet (that is, the Imperial Navy, not the district) has the responsibility of keeping the arches under the bridge and the Lord's Road Canal clear of debris. A worrisome situation, given the Navy's tendency to subcontract to the lowest bidders.